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PUBLICAÇÕES  
DO  
CLUB VINTE DE SEPTEMBRO

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III  
HISTÓRIA  
DA  
REPUBLICA RIOGRANDENSE

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and

ChatGPT 5.5 with  
Extra High Intelligence

# **History of the Rio-Grandense Republic**

## **A Revised English Reading Edition**

Assis Brasil

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This work is yet another effort in the direction of the ideas which I set forth and maintained in *The Federal Republic*. It is my conviction, strengthened more and more by study and meditation, that the most important revolutions which once shook the country, and whose ideal has not yet been satisfied, had as their principal cause the necessity of

establishing the rational system of federation, which may also be called the system of liberty, because liberty is order in accordance with the prescriptions of nature. The Rio-Grandense revolution, which resulted in the republic, is in this sense the most characteristic.

I therefore found myself faced with a double labor: besides that of recounting the facts, I had also to make plain their character. The narrowness of the time at my disposal for the composition of this first volume compelled me to send it to press before it fully satisfied my wishes, especially with regard to the narration of events. I was writing for the Club Vinte de Setembro, which had to present the work publicly on a fixed day.

For this reason I have called this edition preparatory. I hope very soon to be able to issue the definitive one, with the advantage that I shall already be able to make use, for it, of the corrections which competent persons may make to this. Only in this way can one obtain a passable history of a series of events as tangled as it is still unknown.

Nevertheless, I believe that I already advance many things which my predecessors had not yet said, because, besides having at my disposal their materials, I also had recourse to original documents of the highest importance and to certain truthful reports from persons who witnessed the facts. In this respect I received great assistance from General Portinho, the most illustrious survivor of the Rio-Grandense republicans, who, besides a large number of written documents of every kind, also furnished me with precious information concerning events in which he took

part or which passed before his eyes. On a smaller scale, many other citizens, some of them contemporaries of the republic, rendered me real assistance. It is for the volumes that will follow this one that these contributions have helped me most. Yet from this moment I record here my gratitude to them all.

Of works already published, I made principal use of the excellent monograph by Judge Araripe, a work of great merit, because it is a true construction out of elements which had been dispersed and disconnected. Although I find myself in fundamental disagreement with the author's ideas, and even with regard to the accuracy of certain facts, I must confess that in his book I learned more than anywhere else, besides having drunk from it the inspiration to write my own.

I was also much served by several works published in the daily press, such as those of Dr. Ramiro Barcellos, C. von Koseritz, and M. L. do Nascimento. This last gentleman also honored me with some personal information of high value. In general, the other sources are cited in the course of the work.

All that I have affirmed is based upon data of great solidity; but I resorted to citations only when it seemed to me that the question might offer occasion for controversy, or when, in spite of everything, I did not possess unshakable certainty.

One favor I expect from whoever reads this book and is versed in the knowledge of its subject: that he send me

the observations he may make concerning any inaccuracy contained in it. The best course would be to take the notes in the margin itself. Address: São Paulo.

There are many people, particularly in Rio Grande do Sul, who possess a great number of papers from the time of the republic and keep them unused and condemned to loss; yet those papers, in more diligent hands, would be of the greatest profit. I do not hesitate to venture a request to all such persons, chiefly to those who, out of patriotism, may wish to assist in the construction of the history of the glorious republic. Those who do not wish to part with their documents may merely lend them for a time.

Still others keep present in memory many episodes of various kinds that occurred in that period, and possess sufficient ability to describe them. These too would render an inestimable service by sending their information. In these matters everything is useful, everything is interesting, from the smallest adventure to the most resounding event.

Rio, August 1882.

A. B.

## **Chapter I**

I undertake to write the history of the Rio-Grandense Republic: a brief and ephemeral state, raised at the far southern extremity of Brazilian territory, whose tumultuous existence, constantly harried by the arms of the Empire, did not succeed in passing beyond its period

of formation. Never did bravery, constancy, and civic virtues, served by men of scant education, offer of themselves a more surprising spectacle than in that struggle of nearly ten years, which calls up to the historian's mind the traditional tenacity of the ancient peoples.

Numerous and varied were the revolutions that agitated the first days of the Brazilian nation, from north to south; none of them, however, gave it such serious labor in repression, none demanded such considerable sacrifices, none placed national integrity in such imminent danger as the Rio-Grandense revolution. Powerful causes, therefore, must have moved the spirit of the insurgent province, causes capable of determining the exceptional energy of its pronouncement.

Carried away by the fatal habit of attributing everything to the exclusive influence of individuals and nothing to the indefectible laws according to which the historical movement is carried out, the writers who have so far occupied themselves with the Rio-Grandense revolution seek its causes in isolated and immediate facts which, before a more exacting and more rational inquiry, would in their turn require a second and longer explanation. Diverging fundamentally from a method as convenient as it is barren, I shall seek to sketch, together with the historical filiation of the series of events whose narration I propose, the causes which seem to me to explain its origin and prolongation.

No one today can fail to recognize the efficacious influence exercised upon a people by the whole set of physical

circumstances that surround it: the cosmic milieu. And if this fact had not already assumed the character of an accepted and proclaimed law, the example of Rio Grande would still be of great profit, for there the habits and tendencies of the inhabitants were from the outset sensibly adapted to the specific nature of the milieu.

Rio Grande do Sul occupies a broad zone of about three thousand square leagues in surface, bordered for a great part by the Atlantic, which lies to the east, and by the great river Uruguay, which runs along the opposite side, seeking the waters of the Plata, into which it empties. Its astronomical position, analogous to that of the countries of southern Europe, lies between twenty-nine and thirty-three degrees of south latitude. This position, and the complete absence of high mountain chains and deep valleys, cause all winds to blow freely over the whole extent of the territory, with greatest vehemence always in the celebrated minuano, which comes from the direction of the point where the great American cordillera of the Andes gradually lowers and dies away.

From these circumstances derives the fact that in Rio Grande the seasons of the year are sharply defined and characterized. Winter is extremely cold; the more exposed places have at times reached freezing, the mass of ice resisting the action of the sun for three days and more without dissolving. In summer there sometimes reigns an unbearable heat, equal to the most intense heat of the tropics; autumn and spring display a paradisiacal temperature. The rains are abundant in winter and spring;

summer and autumn are, as a rule, dry. Vegetation accompanies this variability. There is not in Rio Grande the luxuriant monotony of the vegetable world observed in the intertropical regions of Brazil.

The soil of none of the other Brazilian provinces can be compared with that of Rio Grande, whose nature and configuration make it, in relation to the rest of the country, what one might call a world apart. The province is naturally divided into two regions: that above and that below the mountain range, of almost equal size. Contrary to what some have written and many suppose, these two regions do not differ in that the first is mountainous and the second plain, for both are equally plain and broken. The difference lies in their height above sea level. The lower part rises, on average, about one hundred feet, with even one city, Rio Grande, not exceeding a height of twenty-eight inches; the upper part presents an average of fifteen hundred feet, with points such as the pass of Santa Victoria, near the headwaters of the Uruguay, which rise to thirty-two hundred feet.

The zone called *Cima da Serra* is a broad strip of land stretching between the Uruguay and the Serra do Mar. This range, which throughout the south of the country runs within sight of the ocean, bends northwest on entering Rio Grande, crosses the province in a western direction, and expires beside the banks of the Uruguay, at the point where that great river already turns its waters markedly toward the south. The Serra do Mar, which in this course takes various local names and is known in the

province by the generic denomination of Serra Geral, is like a step between the upper and lower parts. There the ground rises and no longer sinks. Crossing it, the traveler at once feels this fact when, after walking about six kilometers in continual ascent, he finds himself before an immense plain, whose long hills unfold and succeed one another infinitely, until sight becomes wholly powerless to reach them. The fields above the range are clear and of most beautiful aspect; the hills extraordinarily extensive, some of them forming gentle undulations three kilometers in length; at intervals, leafy groves, round and shadowy woods, display upon imperceptible depressions of the terrain the most poetic effects. Being the highest region, it is also the coldest of the province, although it is the one that lies nearest the tropic.

The lower part lies between the ocean, the range, the Uruguay, the Quaraí, and the Jaguarão. Its aspect is highly variable: covered with sand dunes and innumerable lagoons in a narrow strip more than four hundred kilometers long along the sea coast; absolutely level throughout almost the whole basin of the great rivers of the Platine system; now level, now mountainous in the center, whence radiates a great number of small ranges that are nothing more than buttresses of the Serra Geral, and where the hills present more modest dimensions than those of the high region. It is from above the range that there descend, in great part, the waters of the largest rivers of the lower section, the Uruguay, the Ibicuí, the Jacuí, and the Taquari, the last two crossing the range through a basaltic bed, narrow, deep, and strongly broken.

Some travelers and observers understand that, in an epoch relatively not remote, even long after the submarine uplift which produced the highest parts of the soil, the ocean beat at the base of the Serra Geral, as still happens farther north, and afterward slowly withdrew toward the east and south, as firm and elevated lands were formed upon the beaches by means of alluvia or sedimentary layers. The truth is that the composition and aspect of the soil do incline one toward such a supposition. Future observations, regularly carried out, will certainly come to establish the truth on this point, for mere reports from incompetent persons do not suffice to fix it.

I still remember that, while traveling along the small range of Caverá, between the present municipalities of Alegrete and Rosário, a range completely stripped of woods and covered only with grass, I was profoundly impressed by the singular disposition of parallel and horizontal lines which all the hills presented at the same height and on the face that looked toward the floodplain. It seems that the constant action of the waters must have carved those parallel marks in times which only very deep investigations could approximately determine. Geikie notes similar facts observed in the mountains of Europe; and, only a few years ago, a scientific commission sent by the Argentine government to northern Patagonia was led to analogous conclusions, as may be seen from its report published in 1881. Perhaps this is the explanation for the existence of the broad and beautiful plains of Rio Grande, as well as of the countries that extend through the south of America, across almost the whole basin of the Plata and beyond.

Compared with any of the other provinces, that of Rio Grande is very poor in respect to large vegetation. Great forests are rare there, and none of those that exist equals in vigor and majesty the extraordinary virgin woods of northern Brazil. The primordial conditions for the fertility of the soil are heat and humidity. These two conditions exist in a very insufficient degree in Rio Grande: its very southern latitude subtracts from the rays of the sun a great part of their heat, and the prevailing winds, ordinarily harsh and strong, blowing in all directions, dry out the soil. There is no mountain range, no barrier, to arrest the action of the winds, compelling them to retreat and fall back, dissolved into moisture, upon the ground, as happens with the Andes and the eastern ranges of Brazil. Only upon the slope of the Serra Geral, in the neighborhood of the hilly lands of the upper Uruguay and about the headwaters of that river, do these conditions combine in such a manner as to cause great and true forests to rise there, of useful and abundant timbers, such as the Castelhana wood, the Portuguese wood, and others at various points of the same zone. The moisture inherent to the banks of rivers and streams also causes these to be bordered throughout their length by a fringe, broader or narrower, of good and vigorous woodland, except where the ground is so sandy as to verge upon sterility.

Yet such is the happy composition of the lands that, notwithstanding the unfavorable situation in which Rio Grande is placed with respect to atmospheric phenomena, its soil still contains a prodigious fecundity. The sandy adjacencies of the sea beaches form an exception, being

ordinarily almost absolutely sterile; but even these may, in future times, be transformed by the art of agriculture, as has been done in analogous places in Portugal, in certain maritime counties of England, and as is now being done in the environs of the city of Rio Grande. All the other lands of the province which are not covered with woods are embroidered with very extensive green meadows, over which innumerable species of grasses spread themselves, and the best of them, forming the most succulent pastures known. To form an idea of the exuberant intrinsic power of nourishment which the soil transmits to these pastures, it is enough to consider that for nearly two centuries the same wool-bearing, horse, and cattle breeds, without the least crossing, have fed exclusively upon them and still today display beautiful specimens. In less favored regions, the lack of crossing would have determined a fatal and rapid degeneration in less than half that time. What, then, will the Rio-Grandense plains not produce in pastoral industry when methodical selection, with the progress of the times, brings aid and stimulus to the blind spontaneity of nature?

The fitness of the lands for agriculture is notable, being able abundantly to cover consumption and still to produce a remarkable surplus for export on a large scale. Cereals, maize and wheat in the high places, and rice in the low and marshy ones, thrive there admirably. In short, there is no article of primary necessity in this branch which the province cannot produce, and from which it could not create an extensive commerce.

Its natural riches are incalculable. Besides the gold and silver which in various places form precious veins, all the minerals of most fruitful utility are found in prodigious abundance. Marble of all colors and qualities, from black to the purest white, which has been compared to the best of Carrara, exists in truly inexhaustible quarries, together with other products of the same kind. Iron and coal, those two most powerful auxiliaries of industry, form immense deposits. Especially in the valley of Candiota, where iron also is common in its varied compositions, and where coal in repeated places comes to the surface of the soil, the mineral riches assume a fantastic character.

Nothing is lacking to Rio Grande do Sul.

It is a land that can live in luxury exclusively from its own resources. Everything there is favorable to civilization and to progress, even those circumstances which at first sight appear to be an obstacle.

Such was the theater, described as briefly as possible, in which the long and obstinate struggle was engaged, of which this book will be a pale and imperfect narration. Whoever was born and lived in that land, where nature herself has a singular aspect of masculine generosity, cannot fail to love it with a fanatical love. The adoration of the Rio-Grandense for his native soil has already become proverbial, as has the pride, often imprudent yet always most natural, with which he places it above all its sister provinces. There are lands of this sort, which exercise such influence over their children that they come to identify them with themselves. From the adaptation of

a people to this whole set of surrounding circumstances there is born for it a corresponding nature. The Rio-Grandense character had this origin.

It is, therefore, in the first place, in physical nature, in the ensemble of circumstances that constitute the cosmic milieu, that one finds the first reason, the initial cause, I shall not say only of the revolution, but also of the manner in which it was carried out. To bring out the sanction of this assertion, it will suffice to combine the primordial circumstances with one another, and afterward with the supervening facts that came to collaborate with them. This is the subject of the pages that follow.

## II

The elements from which the population of Rio Grande was formed differ greatly from those which gave origin to the other territories of the country. The first settlers were, in truth, Portuguese; but Portuguese who were no longer, in their turn, the same as those who had previously immigrated to America. They were Azoreans, and in the Azores the primitive Lusitanian population had been modified under the influence of the milieu. It was a strong and persistent race, singularly predisposed to constitute a solid trunk for a new population. The Portuguese of the continent who came later found this original trunk already formed; and, joining themselves to it, could not fail to undergo its influence.

On the other hand there entered Paulistas and Mineiros, already likewise differentiated from the common original base, not only by the immediate influence of the milieu,

but also by the new kind of activity in which they had from the outset exercised themselves. The long and hazardous journeys, the remote explorations in which they were so constant, and which in the end became for them an inveterate habit, must have been of great consequence for the character of these peoples. And it was precisely by virtue of this habit, in many of those assiduous excursions, that the most adventurous among them came several times to Rio Grande and fixed themselves there in great number.

The Spanish contingent was not so insignificant as is generally supposed. The Spaniards dominated for long spaces of time a great part of the territory of the province; besides which, in reciprocal invasions, the two peoples visited one another on various occasions. In my view, the consideration of the traditional rivalry existing between them does not stand in the way, because political antagonisms have never disturbed matters of procreation. What offers a serious impediment to the contact of two races, at least in the first times, is the material or moral repugnance which one feels with respect to the other. This fact, which could not occur between Portuguese and Spaniards, races that approach one another at many points of affinity, I judge to have had some influence in Rio Grande with regard to the crossing of whites with Africans and indigenous peoples.

Brazil was already more or less colonized throughout when Rio Grande began to be peopled, and it was still some time after the first nuclei were established that the African traffic began to flow on an appreciable scale toward the lands of the south. The infamous commerce

could not be carried on there with great advantage: first of all, the difficult and dangerous entrance of the bar, where there was not yet a regular pilotage service, and afterward the poverty of the inhabitants, which did not permit a broad outlet for the black merchandise, must have been obstacles of considerable weight. Thus, by the time of the revolution of the province, although Ethiopian blood had already penetrated into the mass of the population, it was not, however, in sufficient quantity to impress upon it a decisive influence.

The Indian entered still less. It is true that this race tolerably peopled the territory when the first explorers and settlers arrived there; but before the white population radiated outward from the first centers and came into contact with it, supervening events changed the order of things. The Jesuits, penetrating by the Rio da Prata and everywhere with their fine sagacity and foresight, established themselves on both banks of the Uruguay, and chiefly on the left, laying the foundations of the famous Guaranitic Empire. Thither, by using their most effective resources of catechization, they gathered, one may say, the whole indigenous population that wandered through the interior of the territory. To give credence to this fact, it is enough to reflect that in the second half of the eighteenth century, when Gomes Freire de Andrade, in combination with the Spanish army, undertook to dislodge them by force of arms, they succeeded in placing in the field against the allied generals an army of twelve thousand men, while it is certain that throughout the province the indigenous

population did not reach the number of some twenty-five thousand souls at the arrival of the Jesuits.

The administrative system employed by the Jesuits with their Indians of the Missions is well known. In the Seven Peoples, entrance was absolutely and categorically forbidden to whites, whom the priests did not neglect to depict as atheists, possessed by demons, and endowed with all the ugly qualities that imagination and calculation suggested to them. In an official letter addressed to his government, Gomes Freire, sketching this Jesuit doctrine, wrote: "...the prisoners taken at Rio Pardo, being asked for what reason they cut off the heads of the Portuguese when they killed them, said that their blessed Fathers assured them that the Portuguese, even if many wounds were given them, were so possessed by demons that many of them rose again, and that the safest course was to cut off their heads." It is understood that, with these habits, the crossing of Indians with whites would be exceedingly difficult.

In the war against the Spanish and Portuguese armies, the indigenous people, who hurled themselves toward death with the savage courage of fanaticism and ignorance, were extraordinarily decimated. The few who survived preserved the tradition, the customs inculcated by their expelled directors. During the Castilian domination of some forty years, the same system of seclusion was maintained, and the same tendency remained toward the decrease of the population; for besides other reasons that existed for this, the Spaniards, less interested, no longer put into

practice certain empirical rules discovered by the Jesuits which provoked, on the part of those they directed, an astonishing prolificacy.(1) When, in 1801, the celebrated José Borges do Canto conquered the Missions for the Portuguese crown, he already found the population reduced to fourteen thousand individuals. In 1822 the town of São Miguel, which at the time of that conquest had nineteen hundred inhabitants, had fallen to six hundred; São João, in those twenty-one years, fell from sixteen hundred to three hundred; São Lourenço from nine hundred and sixty to two hundred and fifty; Santo Ângelo from nineteen hundred and sixty to three hundred and fifty; São Luiz from twenty-three hundred and fifty to two hundred; São Nicolau from thirty-nine hundred and forty to two hundred and fifty; São Borja from thirteen hundred to four hundred; or, in summary, the whole population from 14,010 to 2,350.

The author of *Economic-Political Memoirs on the Public Administration of Brazil*, from whom I take these data, laments that even at the time when he was writing, 1823, “some governors of that district have opposed whites going there to trade, and even to establish themselves.” Even some time after the independence of Brazil, the Missions were separated from the province, forming an administrative section.(2) From these facts it follows by rigorous conclusion that, if later the aboriginal element cooperated in the formation of the Rio-Grandense population, at least in 1835, the epoch of the revolutionary pronouncement, the admixture of that factor was still negligible. And in fact there were few mestizos at that time. The Indians who

existed in the province were still, in almost their totality, pure caboclos. From them were formed regiments and companies of excellent cavalry, from which the republicans drew good profit, and the legalists still better.

- (1) The married Indians, and all, I believe, upon reaching a suitable age, were obliged by the priests to wake at five o'clock in the morning, but to remain in bed until six.
- (2) Each town has a Corregedor and other civil magistrates, or rather rural captains; the government appoints administrators for them, and a governor who watches over everything. The towns, far from prospering, diminish more and more. About three years ago a troop corps of four hundred Guaranis was drawn from there. Antônio José Gonçalves Chaves, *Memórias econômico-políticas*, p. 32. The author of this excellent work, printed in Oporto, is Antônio José Gonçalves Chaves, a Portuguese who lived in Pelotas, where he was a charqueador.

Fernandes Pinheiro, in his *Annals of the Captaincy of São Pedro*, attributes a preponderant influence among the original elements of the Rio-Grandense population to the "bad leaven" that soon entered into its mass, "the base of this consisting of the refuse of the Nation, of convicts, of immoral and banished women." But this idea, which must be rejected with respect to all Brazil, because the transported convicts could never have been in so great a number that such a leaven could preponderate, is especially false with regard to Rio Grande, where they were

imported in a very insignificant portion. The author of the *Memoirs*, who refutes Fernandes Pinheiro's assertion with great advantage, affirms that, although he lived seventeen years in Rio Grande, he does not remember more than two transported convicts having entered there, "one coming from Porto and the other from São Paulo." As for the customs of the inhabitants, maligned by Fernandes Pinheiro, he affirms that these, "far from being, as the *Annals* say, naturally fierce, fickle, thievish, and dissolute, are on the contrary honorable, upright, humane, hospitable, and modest; that on the estancias one lives very decently; the weaker sex shows no noticeable difference between the countryside and the towns: in general the women of the province are, besides beautiful, intelligent, affable, honest, virtuous, and charitable; and in these virtues those raised on the estancias do not yield to those of the towns." This writer attributes Fernandes Pinheiro's inaccuracies to the fact that he never left Porto Alegre "except for his country house." In fact, it is almost always incomplete observations that give rise to injustices such as these.

In summary, the Rio-Grandense population, and it must be noted that I refer to that which influenced the movement of 1835, is the immediate product of these principal factors: Azorean and Portuguese, Paulista and Mineiro, Spanish; the African and the autochthonous element exercised an almost null action; the great current of Portuguese emigration which, toward Rio Grande as toward all Brazil, directed itself, had there less effect than in other provinces, because it already found the original trunk formed and went on subordinating itself to it, by virtue of

the universal law of adaptation to the milieu. Its action was more energetic from another point of view: in the general direction, in administration, in government; and there I shall still have occasion to consider it before reaching the end of this chapter.

In any case, whether these observations are exact or not, what is real, what is undeniable because it is a fact, is that, whatever the forces may have been that acted at the beginning, from them there emerged as resultant a population of such plasticity that rapidly, in less than four generations, it adapted itself fully to the cosmic milieu into which it was cast and presented the most striking originality. This is the culminating fact, which I hold to be firm and unshakable. When the revolution of 1835 was preparing itself in the mind of the province, the province already possessed a character properly its own, with characteristic usages, customs, and tendencies. It was even the time of greatest originality: the natural forces had realized their complete evolution, and civilization had not yet modified their effects. The existence of the province dated from little more than a century, and it is true that this time is exceedingly narrow for the realization of a fact of this order, which regularly demands the course of many centuries. For that very reason, in order to reconcile principles with reality, it is necessary to consider the energetic properties and conditions of the milieu in which the new population was formed, and the particular dispositions, offered by its constitutive elements, for shaping themselves to that milieu.

One fact which stands out at the slightest observation is that in this work the ascendancy of surrounding nature over the population was very pronounced. All the peculiar characteristics of the people, all its habits, and the very type of physical constitution are in the most rigorous correlation with the particular circumstances of the milieu.

The astronomical position of the province makes its climate exceedingly cold, and the nature of the soil, completely unsheltered toward the seas of the south and toward the open and level regions of the Pampas, aggravates this circumstance still more, causing it to be easily and constantly visited by airs almost icy from the neighborhood of the pole. This temperature impresses a special tone upon the fiber of the inhabitant. Peoples who inhabit cold countries, when this phenomenon is not carried to excess, generally display a rigid and strong organization and acquire greater agility and persistence for the labors of life. The white race in particular presents these results; nor is there any other explanation for a great part of the merits of the Saxon race and of those which have affinity with it or are its branches. In Brazil, the differences which the various temperatures have been establishing from the equator southward are sensible and well known; but nowhere are they reflected so strikingly as in Rio Grande, where, moreover, other causes, as we shall see, combine with this one to construct a special type.

But the cold is not permanent. In summer, when the repeated displacements of the polar atmosphere cease, there ordinarily reigns, together with the great calms, a stifling

and distressing heat. By reason of the atmospheric purity, the rays of the sun become at times as ardent as if they did not fall obliquely upon the earth. This contrast of cold and heat, both carried to an exaggerated degree, accustoms the individual who endures such an alternation to resist with equal valor every sort of inclemency. Especially in the hardships of war, a man suffers bitterly from the action of a climate to which he was not habituated, or from the alternation of suns and rains, which produces an analogous effect. This cannot happen to the Rio-Grandense. It is known that the province furnishes an excellent soldier, in whom the courage with which he charges upon the enemy is not more admirable than the constancy with which he resists the hostilities of nature.

The aspect of the soil, as well as the kind of its productions, also acts decisively not only upon the physical constitution of the individual, but chiefly upon his moral attributes. Thus the inhabitant of the forest is generally timid and little spirited, as if he partook of the gloomy nature that surrounds him. Garibaldi, when he was serving his apprenticeship in arms in the service of the Rio-Grandense Republic, had occasion to observe, in the terrible retreat through the Serra das Antas, that the dwellers of those forests were almost all hostile to the republican cause and, above all, treacherous and cowardly, attacking from ambushes and fleeing after the insidious blow. This observation of the great general, which is found in his *Memoirs*, is very exact and of great reach. The man of the forest cannot have the same ideas, still less the same sentiments, as the man of the open plain. On the plain,

even those who have an innate tendency toward treachery cannot easily exercise it. In the dark thickets, on the contrary, the very aspect of nature awakens in man the germ, the itching of perverse inclinations. The valor of the spirit increases in proportion as it can act more unconfined and free; and nothing fills it so much with a grave joy and with the consciousness of its own strength and greatness as a great picture, a vast, broad, and smiling prospect of nature. The immense green plains of Rio Grande, leaving aside other results, must have been, by their aspect and beauty alone, an impulsive force of great weight, contributing to give to the soul of its inhabitants the excellent temper of which it is made.

Food in Rio Grande is solid, succulent, abundant, and absolutely free of principles injurious to health. Farinaceous foods, in general, have almost no use. Manioc flour itself, which is manufactured in large quantity, is consumed in a degree much inferior to that of the northern provinces.

Meat is eaten, and meat of the best, the freshest, and most substantial kind. Cattle are so abundant and exist spread throughout the whole province with such great prodigality that this excellent food belongs indistinctly to rich and poor. Bloody meat is devoured with the best of appetites; a piece of it thrown carelessly upon the fire and only toasted, this is the genuine churrasco, that typical dish of the gaúcho.

After each meal, and at every hour, one ingests, one after another, some dozens of gourds of bitter mate, *chimarrão*. The digestive, diuretic, and sudorific properties of mate

complete what the meat began. A strong expansive vigor is transmitted to the whole body, and thought, like every function, shares in the agility of the organs.

Modern science unanimously proclaims the importance that must be attached to food as a sociological factor. Already La Mettrie, the cheerful philosopher, companion and friend of the great Frederick, exalted the virtues, “the enormous power that there is in a meal,”(1) and attributed the particular character of the English to their habit of eating bloody meat. Upon more rational bases Taine(1) maintains this same opinion, and Buckle(2) expounds and fully justifies it with his habitual eloquent clarity. In Rio Grande the fact occurred in such a way as to produce its effects as energetically as possible. When the province was peopled, it was already stocked with cattle, which always, down to the present, exceeded by far the necessities of consumption and determined a considerable exportation. In the first times, moreover, as had to result from superabundance, the article was extremely cheap, indeed the cheapest, though the best, of all foodstuffs. As for mate, the same occurred: it was manufactured in the province itself, where there are inexhaustible and excellent *hervais*, and often by the consumer himself. The facility there was for the continuous action of this powerful agent, food, explains the rapidity with which its effects manifested themselves.

(1) *Man a Machine*, Chapter VII.

In provinces of the north, in Ceará and Piauí, for example, animal food is also found in broad abundance; but its

effects will inevitably be different, operating in a climate almost invariably torrid and upon the northerner, devourer of flour, tidbits, and irritants.

- (1) H. Taine, *History of English Literature*. (2) H. T. Buckle, *History of Civilization in England*.

In this sense, the clearest comparison that can be established is between the *caipira* of São Paulo and the *gaúcho* of Rio Grande. The *caipira*, who generally feeds on beans, cornmeal, and coffee, presents a valetudinarian aspect: dull complexion, slack and extinguished gaze; he is bent, yellow, toothless. The *gaúcho* is robust, ruddy, and muscular; he has a restless and penetrating gaze, white and strong teeth, a straight spine, the neck solidly planted upon broad athletic shoulders. Those who live in the cities degenerate, as a rule, from this type, whereas in the province of São Paulo this circumstance of residing in centers, or amid abundance, determines serious improvements. Leprosy, elephantiasis, as well as almost all cutaneous affections, are maladies unknown in Rio Grande.

Industry, comprehending under this denomination every kind of material activity of a people, furnishes in Rio Grande the exercises most appropriate for the development of the moral and physical faculties of individuals. It is determined, as always happens, by the very constitution of the milieu. Its insufficiency for great vegetation and, at the same time, the superior intrinsic qualities of the soil determined the existence of the compact grass that carpets the greater part of the province, natural pastures able to compete with the best in the world. From this resulted the

fact that the plains, over the whole extent of the territory, became covered, with an astonishing and inexplicable rapidity, by innumerable herds of varied species of live-stock. The nature of this element of industry, equally precious and easy of acquisition for all, produced these two facts: it more or less leveled the conditions of fortune, by the convergence of interests toward the same point, and provoked in all an equal activity in that confluence of interests.

Inertia is impossible in Rio Grande. Even the life which there is considered indolent and lazy is full of troubled activity. The labor of the estancias is reputed an amusement, and as such the gaúcho accepts it; yet there is no more barbarous and fiery toil than this, in which life itself is in danger at every moment: now in the horse-breaker, who, fixed upon his saddle, resists the terrible bucks of the wild colt; now in the field hand, who darts at loose rein, with dizzying speed, over lands riddled with holes and precipices; now in the lassoer, who fearlessly affronts, communicating to the horse the agility of his own body, the indomitable fury of the angry bull upon the height of a deserted hill. The making of a drove and its conduction to the charqueada can be compared only to the harsh labors of war. Whether it rains, whether the sun scorches, whether the cold whistling minuano blows, the labor does not cease. The gaúcho goes out at dawn to his fatigues and often returns from them only when night is closed. Not rarely he supports during the whole day a forced fast, and he is so habituated to these vicissitudes that he

almost always neglects to provide himself at home with the necessary cold provisions.

On the march, the cruelty of suffering is redoubled: to guard the drove, to enclose it, to subject it in its stampedes, to gather it when, by virtue of one of these accidents, it disperses in various and unknown directions, in continual danger of being crushed by the weight of his own horse or torn by the hoofs of the cattle in narrow passages where the drove, suddenly assailed by unexpected panic, moves rapidly and compactly in an immense mass, and does not retreat before efforts, shouts, and pistol shots. Such is the life of the great number of Rio-Grandenses who embrace the profession of drover. The service begins at the time when the rigor of the dog days reigns and always enters into the season of frosts, until the month of June. More or less similar are all the other modes of life. The gatherer of mate, who painfully watches the *carijo* through whole nights, and the cart-driver, who in his long and slow journeys struggles against the inclemencies and the hostilities of the terrain, have no life less varied, less active, or less laborious. The products of agriculture are carried by the producers themselves through the countryside in quest of exchange or sale for money. Commerce itself in the countryside is exercised by peddlers, who make prolonged excursions through it, conducting goods in carts and following in everything the inveterate habits of the inhabitants. Today this habit is modified, but it is not extinct.

All this, all these difficulties and bitternesses, are supported, I shall not merely say with resignation, but with heroic and sincere joy; and this constant labor, to which the nature of man grows accustomed and adjusts itself, hardens his organization and reflects analogous consequences in his character.

One observation which at this point must not be forgotten is that relative to the effects of the contagion which the neighboring Hispano-American peoples exercised upon the province of Rio Grande from the earliest times. This contagion, of which for the present I treat only as a co-determinant of the specific type of the province, exerted itself in two most efficacious ways: by the infusion of Hispano-American blood into the Rio-Grandense group, and by the imitation of usages and customs. An opinion now very current even carries these facts to the exaggeration of considering them the sole factors of the Rio-Grandense character. Such is their importance.

Of the cooperation of race I have already treated in speaking of the formation of the population; the influence of usages and customs is of incontestable weight. The tendency toward imitation is natural to the whole human species, and in it resides in great part the explanation of the entire evolutionary movement of humanity. The more two peoples touch by common points of resemblance, the more decisive and patent are the effects of imitation. Rio-Grandenses and Hispano-Americans of the south inhabit, one may say, the same zone; for a long time there was not even a determined frontier line separating them; for

a long time considerable waves of one people and the other reciprocally invaded the neighboring dominions. Brazil once legally had as the extremity of the country the immense mouth of the Plata; the Hispano-Americans had already planted their boundary marks in the heart of Rio-Grandense territory and along the course of the Ibicuí. From this ebb and flow there remained considerable residues, to which the geographical similarity of the countries of the two peoples, and even the analogy of the races, lent transcendent importance. Thus are explained the similarities existing between the two in character, usages, customs, and even language. The differences, however, are more numerous than the similarities, which is very easy to understand in view of the initial diversity of the two peoples.

It was from this concurrence of circumstances, summarily set forth, the influence of climate, of the nature and aspect of the soil and of its consequent productive capacity, the plasticity of the original population, food, industry, contagion with the neighboring race, that there germinated and grew the distinctive type of the Rio-Grandenses, that vigorous and solid type which alone would suffice to explain the strange impetus of their revolution. Add to all this a countless number of other secondary causes awakened by the idea of these; consider the innate sentiment of pride and haughtiness which the contemplation of the beauties and superiority of a land he loves so much infuses into the Rio-Grandense, a land resplendent with marvels, predisposed to incline all spirits toward outbursts of poetic enthusiasm; consider the sentiment of independence

latent in each man, through the conviction in which all are held that the province, which contains within its bosom, in the most ample superabundance, everything necessary to life, has no need of bonds of subjection to a foreign element in order to preserve itself and progress; consider all these facts, all these sentiments acting constantly upon men for more than a century, reinvigorating themselves through persistence, transmitting themselves by heredity from generation to generation, ever more pronounced, ever more incisive, and one will understand without effort the nature and the effects of a movement that issued from the heart of this people, prepared in such a manner by energetic precedents.

### III

In the relation existing between the province of Rio Grande and the nation against which it rebelled, the causes of the revolutionary fact must also be studied.

In this kind of inquiry, what first looms large is the difference, the profound divergence that is observed between the constitution of the whole and the constitution of the part, between Brazil and Rio Grande. Effectively, there is no province so diverse from the rest of the country as the province of Rio Grande, which, strictly speaking, has with any of its sisters no exact point of geographical or ethnographical coincidence. It seems to me that the preceding pages are sufficient to prove this.

What this natural order of things clearly required was that the institutions with which it should be clothed not be antagonistic to its character. Everywhere, a rational

system of political institutions ought to be no more than the reflection, the repercussion, if one may so speak, of the system of conditions upon which it is established. Now this was precisely what in Brazil was always ignored and denied, especially with regard to Rio Grande, and much more in the time of the Empire than in that of the colony. From this province, so characteristically original, our men intended, by the simple and ineffectual influx of legislation, to make a part in every respect equal and similar to the whole to which it was joined only by remote bonds of affinity. Like all the members of the country, it was tied to the center by the fatal bonds of unity ill understood. The law had the foolish intent of leveling that in which nature had established a wise and harmonious inequality.

When legislative force adjusts itself to that of nature, it is fruitful and salutary; it is like intelligence guiding and profiting from the aptitudes of the body. But when it enters into competition with nature, operating in the opposite direction, the victory, which must necessarily fall to nature, is all the more disastrous because it is unaided by conscious effort. The events of Rio Grande were a sad proof of this truth. A great example, whose eloquent lesson nevertheless seems not to have served, down to the present, those for whom it was destined. An organization based upon natural elements, a federative organization, to say everything, established at the opportune time, in which the great organs of this extraordinary country might freely exercise their proper functions, cooperating freely also for the life of the whole, would have parried the repeated blows that more than once were on the point

of cutting forever the thread of national integrity. Liberty is in everything a condition of life and, consequently, of order; they wished to substitute for it atrophying centralization; the result was what was seen: an energetic protest of nature.

Under colonial dominion, Rio Grande, which was the last section of the country to be colonized and which never properly formed part of any captaincy, always constituted an exception. The captains-general, exercising their authority in the name of the king, were absolute governors and independent in fact. The placement of the Rio-Grandense captaincy, whether in relation to the rest of the country or in relation to the Spanish colonies, guaranteed it this exceptional position. The conflicts between Portugal and Spain were joined and decided upon the frontiers of its territory. It was rather a strategic point than an administrative division. One can never overstate the reach of this circumstance in the formation of the Rio-Grandense character. The people became essentially warlike; the habits of a continual military agitation were strongly impressed upon its nature; and at the same time, the fact of defending its interests almost always with its own resources accustomed it still more to the idea of independence, already insensibly implanted in its spirit by the antecedents of which I have had occasion to speak. The people abominated the government of the captains-general, which was, in effect, arbitrary and cruel. When the regime changed through the independence of Brazil, the names of those authorities were remembered only with execration; but what is true is that, together with that harsh

tyranny, the faculties of the future province developed and the direction of its innate tendencies was fixed, and the very residue of hatreds and rancors left by the old system contributed to accentuate and define them with greater clarity.

The independence of Brazil came, and with it the political and administrative regime that still endures today without notable difference. The people experienced the explosive joy of one who frees himself from an unbearably distressing state. It believed itself in the presence of a solution of continuity between past and future, entering into a new era, pregnant with improvements, with liberty, and with progress. The spectacle of things, however, soon made it see that the new regime was no more than a prolongation of the old and detested one, that the modifications had been apparent. The province continued to be governed like the captaincy, with this single difference: that the government of the new metropolis was exercised more directly than that of the old, and precisely when it was less necessary, so that the evils of centralization, if they already existed, were aggravated still more.

To the general state of irritating discontent which these things produced was added the continual alarm in which, for some years, spirits lived, fearing a return to the colonial period. These suspicions were authorized by the conduct of the individual who seated himself upon the throne: Portuguese by birth, surrounded by Portuguese, and educated in the practices of absolutism, the only ones he knew. The first national assembly that met, the assem-

bly that should have dictated the political constitution of the state, had been dissolved by armed force through the direct intervention of the young emperor, absolutist and absolute, and its members expelled and persecuted. The entire country was agitated; everywhere commotions appeared on a greater or lesser scale; in some places there were even bloody crises. The news of these events, already grave in themselves, reached Rio Grande colored with the exaggeration which time and distance are accustomed to impress upon events. The fear of Portuguese reaction assailed every spirit; the idea of resistance also began to dawn and to become common among all. A perennial distrust was the distinctive feature of the epoch.

The individuals whom the government of Rio de Janeiro sent for the governance of the province differed in nothing, as to political and administrative education, from those whom Lisbon sent with the title of captains-general. First of all, they had the great defect of not knowing the people and the land they were going to direct. Many sons of the province had become highly skilled warriors in the contests with the Spaniards and with the Hispano-Americans; yet the government never placed them in posts of honor. It sent, to command them, old Portuguese generals, inept for war and, besides all this, ignorant of the theater in which they were going to fight and of the special tactics demanded by the wars of the south.

One of these incapable soldiers, foreign to the province, the Marquis of Barbacena, sent to direct the war of 1825, struck upon the Rio-Grandense heart the blow that must

hurt most in a people that supposed itself invincible. Risking without judgment, without method, the battle of Ituzaingó against superior forces commanded by the illustrious Carlos Alvear, he obtained as result the most disastrous defeat that Brazilian arms had ever suffered there. In that battle there were old and seasoned Rio-Grandense officers, who recognized the ineptitude of the adventitious general and attributed their own rout to it alone. The reverse was, for those brave veterans, defenders of the fatherland, an immense pain that wounded not only their patriotism but also their indomitable ancient pride.

There followed the loss of Cisplatina, which, not long before, had been incorporated into Brazil as a province. Although the peoples of the eastern bank of the Uruguay had a sacred right to their independence, nevertheless this victory of the Hispano-Americans, whom an old rivalry separated from the Brazilians, considerably increased the discontent that already existed. One understands how much the arrogance of the victors must have made the vanquished pass through bitter humiliations, still more when these had the conviction that those could justly glory in their triumph, achieved with heroic energy, decided in a pitched battle.

All this accumulation of afflictions and grievances weighed heavily upon the mind of the province. Faith in the paternity of the general government was lost. A rupture was not difficult.

Rio Grande was poor and ruined. It is natural to every people that does not prosper to make the government directly responsible for the misfortunes that pursue it. This occurred in Rio Grande, but with the difference that there the complainants had every reason, even more than they supposed. The central government promoted wars, laid waste the province, sucked away its riches by every means, made use of the services of its valiant sons; only it never took care to dispense to it that protection which becomes necessary to every people at its beginning. Rather it seemed that the entire effort of the center consisted in seeking to dry up the sources of the desolated provincial wealth. The taxes were as exorbitant as they were absurd, preferably burdening those industries whose development ought most to have been stimulated and protected by regular means. Upon dried beef, the *charque*, weighed the extraordinary contribution of six hundred strong réis for each arroba exported, paid at the customhouse of Porto Alegre or that of Rio Grande. The result was that this great industry was rapidly diminishing instead of prospering, while similar products from the Rio da Prata, where only hides of horses and cattle and tallow paid tax, and a very mild one, flowed considerably into the consuming markets.

Cattle hides were subject to the odious tax of the fifth, and this for those exported to national ports; those destined for abroad groaned under a higher contribution. But what made this absurd tax still more absurd was that it had to be paid in the very exported material and not in the corresponding value. Thus, whoever with enormous sacrifices

traversed the countryside buying hides and managed to gather, for example, one thousand, had to deliver two hundred to the treasury, depriving himself of a great part of the advantages that the speculation might provide.

This was still not all: besides these taxes, which extended with equal vexation to all goods, the government ordered, by decree of 16 April 1821, that the tithe also be collected; and to calculate it a table was made so exaggerated that *charque* became subject to another eighty strong réis per arroba; tallow, grease, and yerba mate, per arroba; hides, for each one; and wheat, per alqueire, to another eighty strong réis. This was the principal wealth of the province, its only export at that time, which the government thus crushed beneath the weight of taxes. The fatal result was inevitable: everything languished.

To have an idea of what the people thought of such a plundering system, see what the author of the *Economic-Political Memoirs* says: "We do not know that there is any right to collect tithe from yerba mate, since this product arises from industry and not from cultivation; nevertheless they may found themselves upon some custom, or, to explain ourselves better, abuse. When the priests contended for tithes, they said they were of divine right...; but with all their ambition they demanded no more than the fruits of the earth, and those which did not depend upon industry. Here we are paying tithe on productions of industry, and we do not know what the foundation may be."(1)

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